Jacopo Sacchet[1*], Luca Giussani[1], Alessandro Berlusconi[12]

1: Gruppo Insubrico di Ornitologia, via Alessandro Manzoni 21, Clivio (VA)
2: Dipartimento di Scienze e Politiche Ambientali, Università degli Studi di Milano, 20133 Via Celoria 2, Milano (MI)
*: jacopo.sacchet1@gmail.com

Campi di Brebbia (Varese, Italy): a crucial stopover and wintering site for birds

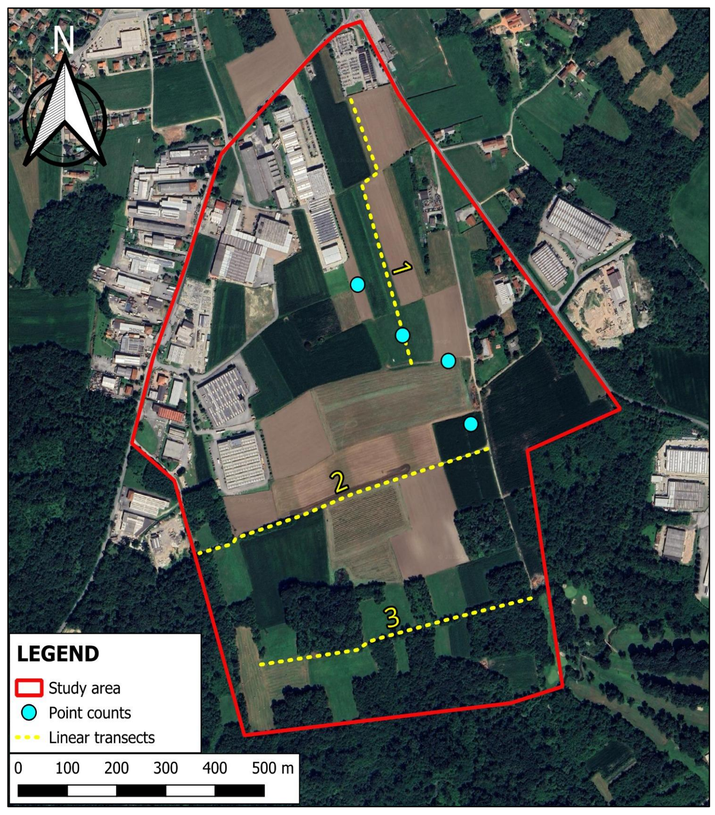
INTRODUCTION

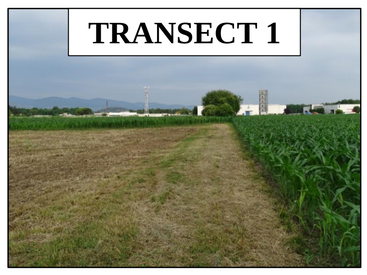
- "Campi di Brebbia" (Brebbia, Varese, Italy) is a 0.86 km^2 farmland.
- 177 bird species were sighted in the area between 2017 and 2024.
- High anthropogenic disturbance and crop banalization are documented pressures.
- No standardized bird surveys have been conducted yet in the area.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

- **38 surveys** between 18/08/2024 and 24/08/2025.
- Each survey = **three linear transects** and **one point count**.
- Overall species richness, per-transect species richness, abundance, Shannon-Wiener and Simpson-Gini indices were calculated.
- Maize crop and tilled surface area (ha) were noted during each survey.
- GLS, linear/generalized mixed models run on Rstudio.

MONITORING SEASONS		
Season	Start date	End date
Post-Breeding migration	18/08/2024	17/11/2024
Winter	24/11/2024	28/02/2025
Pre-Breeding migration	09/03/2025	01/06/2025
Summer	21/06/2025	24/08/2025







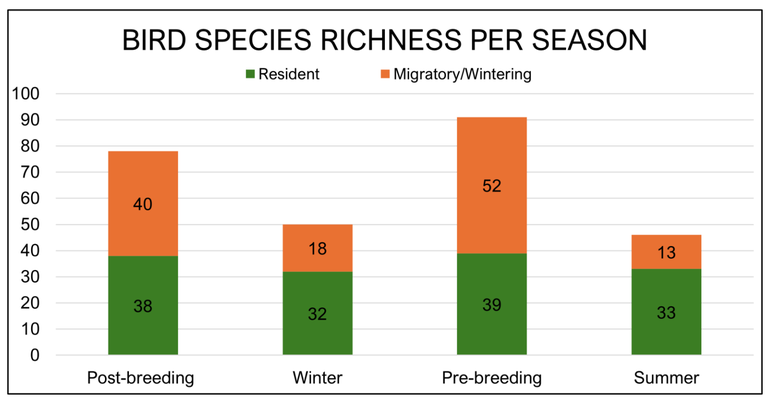


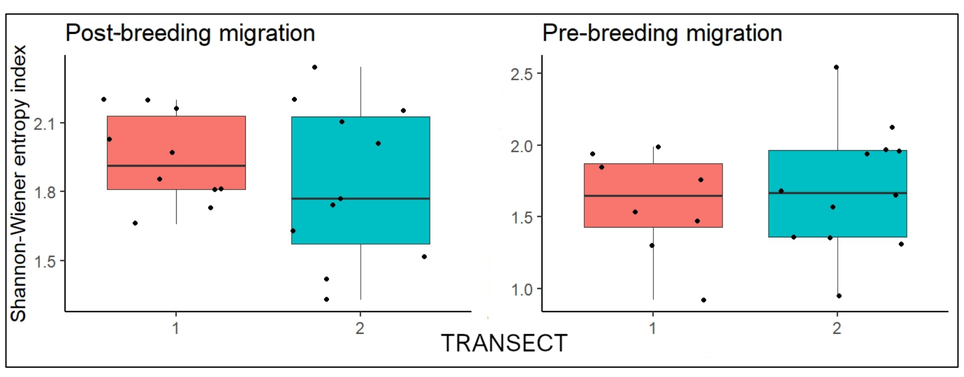
RESULTS

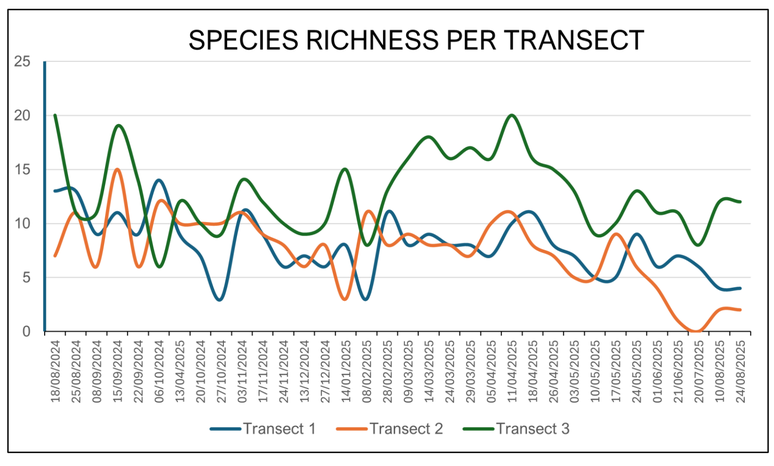
- **110 bird species** detected – **31** (28,18%) of **conservation concern**.
- **First record** ever of Penduline Tit (*Remiz pendulinus*), **second record** of Woodchat Shrike (*Lanius senator*) and ninth record of Greater Short-toed Lark (*Calandrella brachydactyla*). For the latter "Campi di Brebbia" is the only known almost regular stop-over site in the entire province of Varese.
- Julian date = **not a significant predictor** for avian richness and diversity in the area.
- Maize crops **decreased overall species evenness** but had a **mild positive relationship with species diversity** during the post-breeding migration.
- Tillage preferred by Meadow Pipit (*Anthus pratensis*), Western Yellow Wagtail (*Motacilla flava) and* Whinchat *(Saxicola rubetra).*
- Tilled maize cropland preferred by Lapwing (*Vanellus vanellus*) and Skylark (*Alauda arvensis*)
- Mixed fallow-maize cropland preferred by Common Reed Bunting (*Emberiza schoeniclus*) and Stonechat (*Saxicola rubicola*).

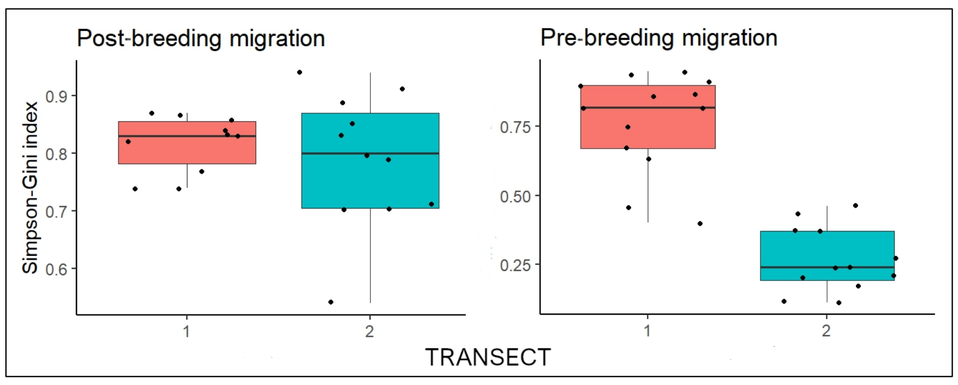
SPECIES OF CONSERVATION CONCERN						
Italian name	Scientific name	All. I DU	LRI IT	SPEC IT	SPEC EU	Class. EU
Airone bianco maggiore	*Ardea alba*	x	NT			LC
Nibbio bruno	*Milvus migrans*	x	LC	3	3	LC
Nibbio reale	*Milvus milvus*	x	VU	1	1	LC
Falco di palude	*Circus aeruginosus*	x	VU			LC
Falco pellegrino	*Falco peregrinus*	x	LC			LC
Pavoncella	*Vanellus vanellus*		LC	1	1	VU
Beccaccino	*Gallinago gallinago*				3	VU
Piro piro boschereccio	*Tringa glareola*	x			3	LC
Picchio nero	*Dryocopus martius*	x	LC			LC
Calandrella	*Calandrella brachydactyla*	x	LC	3	3	LC
Tottavilla	*Lullula arborea*	x	LC	2	2	LC
Allodola	*Alauda arvensis*		VU	3	3	LC
Topino	*Riparia riparia*		VU	3	3	LC
Balestruccio	*Delichon urbicum*		NT	2	2	LC
Pispola	*Anthus pratensis*				1	LC
Stiaccino	*Saxicola rubetra*		VU	2	2	LC
Saltimpalo	*Saxicola torquatus*		EN			LC
Tordo sassello	*Turdus iliacus*				1	LC
Forapaglie comune	*Acrocephalus schoenobaenus*		CR			LC
Beccafico	*Sylvia borin*		EN			LC
Regolo	*Regulus regulus*		LC	2	2	LC
Pigliamosche	*Muscicapa striata*		LC	2	2	LC
Pendolino	*Remiz pendulinus*		VU			LC
Averla piccola	*Lanius collurio*	x	VU	2	2	LC
Averla capirossa	*Lanius senator*		EN	2	2	NT
Passera d'Italia	*Passer italiae*		VU	2	2	VU
Verzellino	*Serinus serinus*		LC	2	2	LC
Verdone	*Chloris chloris*		VU			LC
Fanello	*Linaria cannabina*		NT		2	LC
Migliarino di palude	*Emberiza schoeniclus*		CR			LC
Strillozzo	*Emberiza calandra*		LC	2	2	LC

All. I DU *(Annex I Birds Directive 2009/149/EC);* LRI IT *(Italian Vertebrate Red List 2022);* SPEC IT and SPEC EU *(Species of European Conservation Concern for Italy and Europe);* Class. EU *(Status classification in the European Red List of Birds)*









CONCLUSIONS

- **High importance** of the area during migration and wintering periods for threatened bird species.
- **Poor suitability** of the area **for breeding birds**.
- **Existing mixed-habitat** patches should be preserved.
- **Crop diversity** should be encouraged.

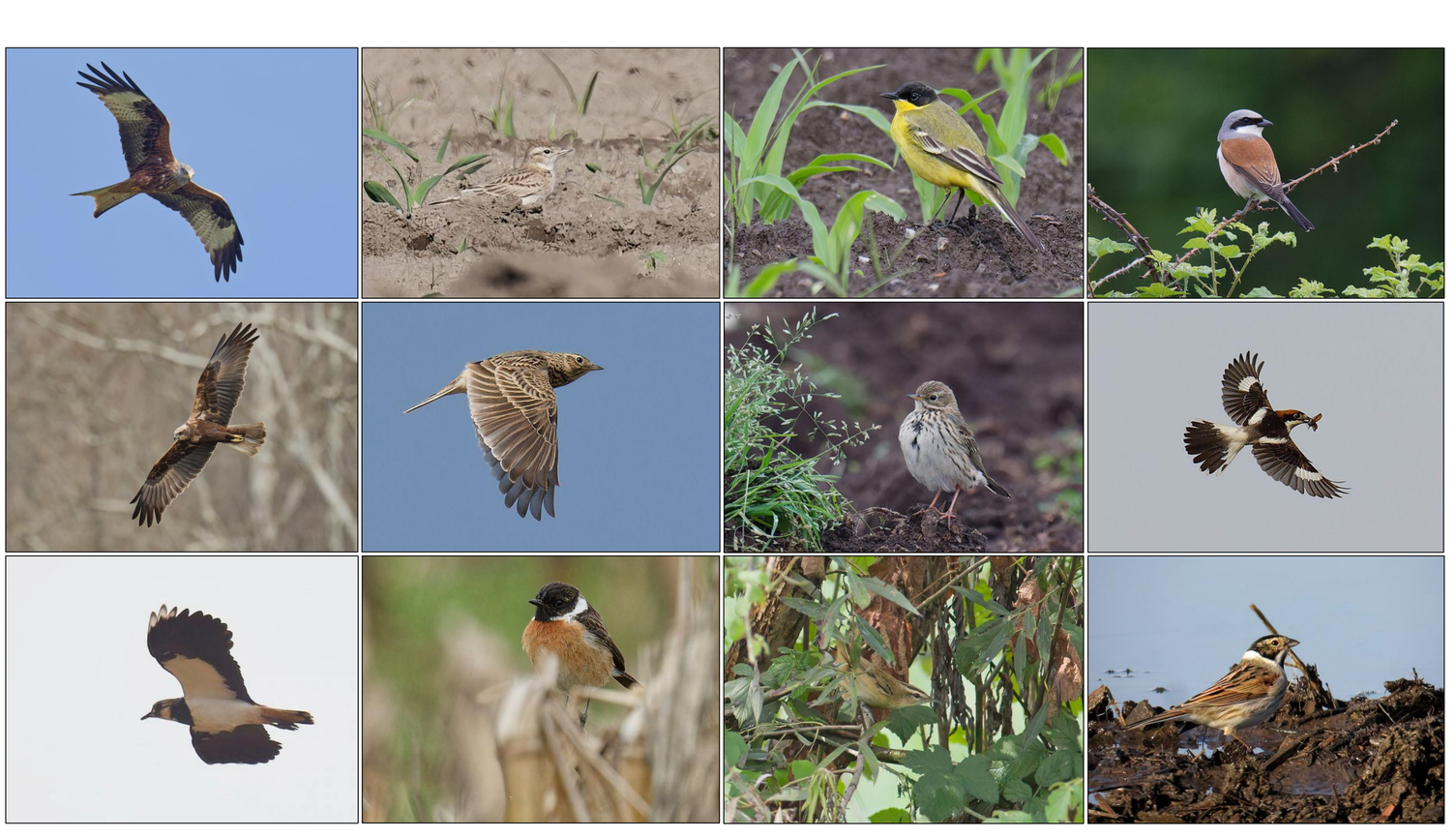
<u>This project serves as a foundation for local conservation actions focused on farmland birds visiting the area.</u>

REFERENCES

Giussani L., 2024. *Relazione preliminare di inquadramento avifaunistico "Campi di Brebbia" - Brebbia/Travedona-Monate (VA). Aggiornamento ad Agosto 2024.*

SCAN ME

We' d like to thank all the people who gave their support during the field monitoring: *Gualtiero Guenzani, Milo Manica, Daniela Casola, Franco Aresi, Silvio Cova, Marco Pergolizzi, Wolfram Wöhler and Jasper Baruth.*



Photos by: *Wolfram Wöhler, Luca Giussani, Jasper Baruth, Jacopo Sacchet*